

NO RIPPLES PM Modi with CM Nitish and other NDA leaders at a rally in Samastipur, Oct. 24

all parties), and among the 'Tejashwi Pran Patra' commitments are Rs 2,500 monthly payouts for all women and Rs 30,000 salary to the 14 million Jeevika Didis (community mobilisers) in the state. On the RJD's prospects, sociologist and professor Gyanendra Yadav of Patliputra University says, "Apart from the M-Y constituency, a significant cohort of aspirational young voters seems attracted to his jobs narrative today." Yet, the professor identifies winning over EBCs and Dalits as a key challenge. A series of pledges are crafted around this: three decimals of land in urban areas and five decimals in rural areas for all landless, scrapping the 50 per cent cap on quotas, a separate judicial system to deal with atrocities against Dalits (as well as for women).

A WELL-CRAFTED CAMPAIGN

Tejashwi's campaign also looks markedly different from 2020. What he lost by a whisker in numbers then, he won in perception—Bihar's youth saw him as a credible alternative. Five years later, he is trying to convert that perception into reality. His campaign slogan, *'Naya Soch, Naya Bihar'*, seeks to reframe the RJD as a party of aspiration rather than grievance.

Also, having secured his position as the MGB's CM candidate, Tejashwi has been hammering home the point that since the NDA has so far not officially declared "*Chacha* (Nitish)" its CM candidate, the old war horse would not be given the post if the ruling alliance wins. Sensing the blowback of such ambiguity, BJP leaders—from Prime Minister Narendra Modi to deputy CM Samrat Choudhary—have begun stressing that the JD(U) chief remains the NDA's CM choice. On October 29, Union home minister Amit Shah even declared that "there was no vacancy

WAR OF PROMISES

From jobs and electricity to pensions and quotas, both sides go all out

MAHAGATHBANDHAN

- **One government job per family:** This will be completed within 20 months of forming the government
- **Jeevika Didis:** Govt employee status, with Rs 30k monthly salary, for 14 mn community mobilisers. Insurance cover, loan relief for SHG women
- **Land for landless:** Three decimals of land in urban areas, five decimals in rural areas for all landless
- **Health:** Free health insurance up to Rs 25 lakh for BPL people, emergency ICUs in all subdivisions
- **Village boost:** Double honorarium, insurance, pension for members of panchayat/gram bodies; honorarium, hiked margins for PDS distributors
- **A step forward:** 50% quota cap to go. EBC quotas in urban/village bodies to be hiked from 20% to 30%
- **Prohibition:** Lift the ban on *tari* (toddy), review Prohibition Act. Immediate relief for jailed poor/Dalits
- **Free power for all:** 200 units for every family
- **Interest-free support for skilled workers:** Traditional communities such as barbers, potters, carpenters and blacksmiths will get a one-time, interest-free financial aid of Rs 5 lakh for five years

NATIONAL DEMOCRATIC ALLIANCE

- **Mass employment drive:** A pledge to create 10 million jobs and employment opportunities over five years
- **Mukhyamantri Mahila Rojgar Yojana:** One-time seed grants of Rs 10,000 to 12.1 million women through self-help groups
- **Women-led businesses:** Up to Rs 2 lakh for women whose business proposals are deemed viable
- **Subsidised electricity:** Up to 125 units/month free power for eligible families, with a push for solar rollout
- **Expanded pensions and targeted welfare:** Higher pension payouts and increased stipends/allowances for vulnerable groups as immediate relief
- **Infrastructure and industry boost:** Commitments to new roads and bridges, health and education recruitments and industry clusters to spur jobs and growth
- **Socio-demographic outreach:** Policy measures and symbolic gestures to consolidate support among OBCs, EBCs, Dalits and economically weaker sections